

Study Questions: Agents — Each Maker at the Table

1. Describe your own **generative model** as a crocheter. What stitches, techniques, and project types does it include? Where are its boundaries — what are you uncertain about?
2. Think of a beginner and an expert in your circle (or imagine two such people). How do their generative models differ in terms of **depth** (detail within a domain) and **breadth** (range of techniques covered)?
3. Why does a beginner experience more **prediction error** than an expert when attempting the same stitch? What does this mean for learning?
4. Consider a circle member who has crocheted for decades but only ever makes one type of item (e.g., blankets in single crochet). Is their generative model deep or shallow? How would you characterize it compared to someone with broad but less practiced skills?
5. How does the **diversity of generative models** in a circle benefit the group as a whole? Give a specific example of how two members with different models help each other.
6. When a member from a different cultural crochet tradition joins the circle, what happens to the group's collective generative model? How might this introduction create productive prediction error for existing members?
7. Explain the concept of **autonomy** within a crochet circle. How does each member maintain their own creative agency while participating in a shared social system?
8. In what ways does the crochet circle function as a **collective agent**? Identify a group-level decision, prediction, or action that no individual member makes alone.
9. How does a member's **aesthetic preference** function as a prior belief in their generative model? How might exposure to others' aesthetic choices update this prior?
10. Think about the role of the **quiet member** — someone who crochets without saying much. How is their generative model being updated during a circle meeting, even without verbal participation?

11. When a circle member takes on a project that is slightly beyond their current skill level, they are deliberately seeking **prediction error**. Why is this a useful strategy for model expansion? What role does the circle play in making this strategy safe?
12. How does the concept of a **shallow generative model** apply to a complete beginner who joins the circle? What are their first prediction errors likely to be about?
13. Describe how the circle acts as a **model-expansion machine**. What specific interactions expand individual members' generative models?
14. Can the circle's **collective generative model** include knowledge that no single member holds individually? Give an example.
15. How do **social knowledge** components of a member's generative model differ from their **technical knowledge** components? Why does a crocheter need both to thrive in a circle?
16. When a circle decides to do a group project (e.g., everyone makes a granny square for a communal blanket), how does the collective agent's decision relate to each individual agent's model? What happens when a member's model conflicts with the group choice?
17. Think about how **project expectations** function as predictions. When a member's project turns out differently than expected (wrong gauge, unexpected drape), what does the resulting prediction error tell them about their generative model?
18. How does **experience asymmetry** — having members at very different skill levels — create unique learning opportunities that would not exist in a group of peers at the same level?
19. Consider two circles: one where all members have similar skills and aesthetics, and one with wide diversity. Which is likely to generate more prediction error? Which is likely to produce more model updating? Why?
20. Reflect on what it means for a crochet circle to have a **group personality**. How does this emergent collective identity arise from the individual agents' models and interactions?